The Arena vs. The Idea

The Fundamental Toxicity of Overly Gamified Minecraft Communities - By Turtle2770

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A YouTuber by the name of Janus recently released a video titled “why i hate minecraft pvp players and dr donut”. The video made some sense, but it encouraged me to voice a deeper issue that I noticed way before its release.

First of all, I believe that the video is a bit of a smear campaign. While some things it says may be true, I got the sense that, just like in political ads, Janus was taking the absolute worst actions and behaviors of DrDonut and displaying them for everyone to see. Even worse, the majority of the video was a personal attack on DrDonut as a person. Although I have opinions on how things should be done, I would never go as far as to say PvPers or DrDonut are inherently soulless, bad people. Janus went too far in his ideas to the point that he is no better than the people he is attacking.

However, much of what Janus mentioned has some truth to it, and I think that there is a huge issue within the community that goes further than any game mechanic or server. In my mind, what makes Minecraft so special is that it means a range of things to so many people. For me personally, it is a sandbox for me to pour out my deepest thoughts, feelings, and desires onto a blank canvas and to see it interact with the gameplay of others. It’s an exhibition of culture and the human spirit that transcends words, bringing a deeper sense of self and others to my life. So what this means to me is I don’t care if you PvP, or if you mine, or if you build a cozy house. You should play how you want to play the game. If we happen to play in different ways, that's

okay. We can make a compromise or just not play together. We don't all have to be friends.

Yet, I think many parts of the Minecraft community don't respect other people and playstyles. This is apparent with PvPers, and even with Janus himself with transphobic rhetoric in his video. As mentioned by Janus, the PvP community in particular encourages feelings and rhetoric that are inherently anti-thinking, anti-intellectual, and high-ego.

They condition you to believe that you are, or can be, better than someone else. If you play a certain way, or you grind more and more, this will allow you to climb the ranks and "become a champion". So, in order to do so, they believe that they need to make sacrifices and be strong (the same exact issue I see in high school sports way too often in the United States, and I say this as a captain of a cross-country team). Often, the first things to go are critical thinking and creativity, since, in order to "be a champion", these skills are seen as weaknesses that are not required for "greatness". Your entire identity becomes based on a rank and how well you do. Terms like "digger" are used to reinforce the concept for the group, so if any individual tries to act differently, the group calls them a "digger" to protect conformity. It has exactly the same goal as any other slur: demeaning any other group of people that is different from your own. It's the same strategy that slave owners used in the United States all those years ago.

As time goes on, people in this community lose more and more of their creative capacity and critical thinking abilities (this, too, is currently being accelerated by AI, but that is a topic for another time). They forget what it's like to enjoy a base, have a non-transactional relationship, and see the strengths and weaknesses in each other as fellow humans. So, they become hostile.

This, I believe, is anti-IMS, the opposite of what we hope to create. The community has been becoming increasingly toxic. It has gotten to the point where, recently, a teacher asked me, “Hey, I see how much you like Minecraft and how great it really is. I am thinking of encouraging my son to join. What do you think?” I responded saying that he should be really careful about the prospect. Minecraft, when enjoyed as an expression of one's soul, is an amazing place. It is the best possible environment, in my opinion, to join together with other people and truly “create your heart out”, and that's why I love this game more than any other on the planet. However, I told the teacher, there are people, specifically those in the PvP and Civ communities, who are motivated by all the wrong reasons. I feel bad that this is the reality and that I didn’t come across as a great Minecraft advocate, but I felt I needed to warn the teacher. These same problems, too, apply to games like Fortnite, Call of Duty, and many other stat-based games. It just pains me to see this community devolve into those same, almost subhuman, beastly ways.

One final note: I think all of this is wrapped up well in the “digger” metaphor that Janus mentioned for two reasons:

1. It is suspiciously close to a slur, and I would not at all be surprised if the PvP community does this on purpose. These same problems, too, contribute to these people creating an exclusionary mentality. The slur they use represents this problem well.
2. If you build, if you create, if you think, then you are playing the game wrong. This is the implicit belief of many PvPers, and even of some student-athletes I know in real life.

I have no suggestions on how to fix this problem, but I can say that it is far more extensive than changing mechanics. Perhaps they should hide the leaderboard, or perhaps they should broaden their view, but something needs to change. I understand not everyone may have my experience,

and that's okay; I am simply speaking from my personal experiences in the Minecraft community and how I have seen different groups act.

I believe that Janus happened to, perhaps accidentally, scratch the surface of a much deeper problem that I have had to deal with for my entire life growing up in the United States. It’s a problem I have been thinking hard to solve, a problem that motivated me in the IMS mission statement, and a problem that I hope to ease as much as I can.

Of course, everything I said here is based on my own personal experience and opinions, both of which could change over time. I am certainly generalizing to a degree, as not every competitive community is toxic, especially those in real life. For example, I have had a good experience with the cross country team, besides a few people. I simply thought that my thoughts here might have some truth to them, and I wanted to bring attention to this issue.